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Abstract

This study employs a multi-method research design to examine how remote workers, or employees who work solely from home, manage the work–family interface. Our qualitative study revealed that working from home creates unique challenges for remote workers because the work role becomes embedded in the family domain such that their home comes to be associated with the work role, work physically and psychologically intrudes upon their family, and habits and norms form that induce remote workers to be preoccupied with work when home. Based on the qualitative findings, a model was proposed and tested via a questionnaire. Findings from this study of remote workers demonstrated that work–family integration increases family-to-work conflict and work-to-family conflict, and that an inability to disengage from work increases work-to-family conflict. Furthermore, strong work–family integration was found to be particularly harmful to male remote workers' work-to-family conflict whereas a strong inability to disengage from work was found to be particularly harmful to female remote workers' work-to-family conflict. Our findings therefore revealed that working solely

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from home encourages remote workers to overwork and to allow their work to infringe on their family role.

Keywords

work-life balance, telecommuting, gender

Well that's the hard part. When you are working in the office, once you leave the office you mentally detach everything from work. You're done! Now your time is with family. But I still have work to do. I know I've got to go back to finish because my office is just two steps away. Nothing is preventing me from going and finishing the work I was doing. So the draw to finish the work is there . . . that pressure is always in the back of your mind. You cannot put off work.

—Interviewee (male remote worker)

Managing remote work represents one of the key challenges of management in the information age (Breugh & Farabee, 2012). Industry reports suggest that most *Fortune 500* organizations now have a home-based sales force (Fell, 2015). Organizations find home-based employment appealing as it enables them to locate workers close to customers, increase productivity, and reduce costs associated with traditional offices (Breugh & Farabee, 2012). For employees, the attractiveness of home-based work is grounded on expectations of the flexibility in scheduling work and family demands and the elimination of a daily commute that are presumed to alleviate work-family conflict (Lautsch, Kossek, & Eaton, 2009).

Because of the high flexibility and autonomy associated with working from home, an employee can control where, when, and how work is performed, and the management of work and family demands is believed to be facilitated (Bailey & Kurland, 2002). A meta-analysis of 46 studies by Gajendran and Harrison (2007) demonstrated that working from home lowers work-family conflict and that the benefits increase for those who work from home more frequently. However, research also shows that most telecommuters work from home an average of 1 to 3 days per week and tend to view the *occasional* ability to work from home as a reprieve from the office (Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Golden, Veiga, & Simsek, 2006; Raghuram & Wiesenfeld, 2004). In contrast, remote workers work *solely* from home, and therefore their approach to managing work and family is likely to be different from that of telecommuters. In addition, although both remote workers (i.e., employees who work solely from home) and telecommuters (employees who

work from home part-time) pose important challenges for managers, the vast majority of research on home-based work focuses on telecommuters (Gajendran & Harrison, 2007). Scholars have lamented over the little theory on the effects of remote work and the lack of empirical research exploring this phenomenon (Bailey & Kurland, 2002; Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Kossek, Kalliath, & Kalliath, 2012).

Our study draws from boundary theory to explore how remote workers manage the work–family interface, particularly focusing on how the physical integration of work and family in the home influences family-to-work conflict (FWC) and work-to-family conflict (WFC). Boundary theory suggests that being continuously and simultaneously available to work and family may breed conflict for remote workers. However, while boundary theory research tends to assume that the workplace and home are separated by physical, spatial boundaries (e.g., Ashforth, Kreiner, & Fugate, 2000; Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2009; Rothbard, Phillips, & Dumas, 2005), for remote workers the workplace is embedded in the family domain. As such, the integration of work and family's physical boundaries might exacerbate the stress of remote workers by creating confusion as to which role, work or family, should take precedence in the home. In line with research that emphasizes a person-centered approach to boundary management (Kossek et al., 2012; Kreiner, 2006), it is also necessary to consider how the (mis)alignment between a remote worker's boundary preferences and the work–family boundary climate created in one's home impact the remote worker's work–family conflict and stress.

In addition, because gender roles are deeply ingrained in work–family interactions (Eby, Casper, Lockwood, Bordeaux, & Brinley, 2005; Powell & Greenhaus, 2010), gender may affect how remote workers manage the work–family interface and experience working from home. For example, women appear more likely to appreciate the integration of work and family that working from home provides (Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Sullivan & Lewis, 2001). However, boundary theory research has shown that women tend to desire greater segmentation between work and family (Powell & Greenhaus, 2010; Rothbard, 2001). Thus, it is necessary to explore whether gender plays a role in remote workers' capacity to manage work and family (Wight & Raley, 2009). Accordingly, we sought to (a) explore how working from home creates benefits and challenges for remote workers, (b) understand how working from home affects remote workers' ability to transition between work and family roles, and (c) investigate how male and female remote workers manage the competing demands of work and family. Employing a multi-method design, results from a qualitative study of remote

workers were used to generate a model of the work–family interface to then be tested via a survey-based study.

Our research reveals the multiple layers of the work–family interface that remote workers must manage suggesting that one continuum of work–family integration/segmentation does not fully capture how remote workers navigate work–family boundaries. In addition, for many remote workers it appears that the physical and psychological presence of work in the home encourages habits and norms to form that induce them to be persistently pulled to work. We refer to this phenomenon whereby the distinction between work and home erodes as workplace embeddedness. Below, we review the work–family literature and then present our qualitative study. This is followed by the presentation of our survey-based study. The article concludes with an integrated discussion of our two studies’ findings and the theoretical implications including the workplace embeddedness phenomenon discovered through our research.

The Work–Family Interface of Remote Workers: Applying Boundary Theory to “Boundaryless Work”

Remote work is a growing trend around the globe. Although a vast majority of research on employees utilizing flexible work arrangements has focused on those who work from home intermittently, it is not known how remote workers experience the work–family interface (Breaugh & Farabee, 2012; Mulki, Bardhi, Lask, & Nanavaty-Dahl, 2009). Such research is necessary because studies indicate that employees prefer to work from home part-time rather than to work solely from home (Bailey & Kurland, 2002; Wight & Raley, 2009). As such, research is needed that investigates the work–family interface of remote workers and how their management of work–family boundaries affects work–family conflict and stress.

Work–family conflict draws from theories of resource scarcity and resource drain to propose that because work and family demands are mutually incompatible, negative emotions, attitudes, and behaviors result (Martins, Eddleston, & Veiga, 2002). Conflict can occur from work-to-family (WFC) or from family-to-work (FWC). In this study, we use WFC and FWC to refer to conflict that clearly occurs in a specific direction, and the term “work–family conflict” to capture the general and reciprocal conflict that exists between work and family. Our use of the term *family* is in line with research that characterizes family broadly to refer not only to those with whom one lives with and kin but also to those with whom one has developed close,

social relationships such as an unmarried partner and close friends (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012; Kossek et al., 2012). Therefore, our view of work and family is similar to others' depiction of work and nonwork, work and home, work and life, and professional and personal life (e.g., Allen, Cho, & Meier, 2014; Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015; Kreiner et al., 2009; Powell & Greenhaus, 2010).

Boundary theory captures how individuals create and maintain boundaries between work and family so as to simplify and order the world around them (Ashforth et al., 2000; Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015). It describes how individuals erect "mental fences" around work and family to construct boundaries between these roles and the consequences of these "mental fences" for boundary management (Kreiner et al., 2009; Nippert-Eng, 1996). In turn, boundary management is characterized as a tool that assists in the handling of work and family responsibilities and helps shape workplace identity and relationships (Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015). Boundary theory is similar to work–family border theory (Clark, 2000), in that both view the work–family interface as socially constructed and acknowledge that individuals enact and shape their work and family environments as well as the borders between them. Whereas boundary theory focuses on "how individuals engage in daily role transitions as part of their organizational life" (Ashforth et al., 2000, p. 472), border theory focuses on "how individuals manage and negotiate the work and family sphere and borders between them in order to attain balance" (Clark, 2000, p. 751). Research on boundary theory often draws from Clark's (2000) work–family border theory as well as Nippert-Eng's (1996) study on boundary work to explain how individuals use physical, temporal, and psychological borders to demarcate work and family (Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015; Kreiner et al., 2009; Powell & Greenhaus, 2010).

In her research on boundary work, Nippert-Eng (1996) discussed how workers construct, remove, and maintain boundaries between their work and family lives. Her qualitative study revealed a pattern of behaviors that distinguished "integrators" (i.e., using the same calendar for work and family activities) from "segmentors" (i.e., using separate keys rings for work and home). Building on this research, Kreiner et al. (2009) showed how the degree of integration between work and family was idiosyncratically constructed. Whereas some individuals labeled "segmentors" rarely brought elements of one domain into the other, individuals labeled "integrators" preferred to remove boundaries between the two domains. Accordingly, boundary management strategies are theorized to fall along a continuum from full integration to full segmentation (Kreiner et al., 2009; Rothbard et al., 2005).

Two factors are believed to characterize integration versus segmentation: flexibility and permeability (Ashforth et al., 2000; Clark, 2000). Flexibility

reflects the extent to which a boundary can expand or contract thereby allowing one domain to accommodate the demands of the other. Permeability captures the degree to which elements from one domain are allowed to enter the other. Boundaries described as flexible and permeable support integration whereas those described as inflexible and impermeable support segmentation. However, whether integration or segmentation between work and family lessens or spurs work–family conflict is debated.

Integration may ameliorate work–family conflict because flexible and permeable boundaries allow individuals to easily transition between roles (Olson-Buchanan & Boswell, 2006). Greater integration enables individuals to cope with multiple demands by allowing them to manage problems in any domain (Powell & Greenhaus, 2010; Rothbard et al., 2005). Conversely, some research stresses the need for segmentation. Segmentation can buffer against negative spillover and help individuals preserve the unique essence of each role (Ashforth et al., 2000). Indeed, Powell and Greenhaus (2010) found that greater segmentation between work and family reduces WFC. Therefore, whereas integration may provide flexibility to cope with multiple work and family demands, segmentation may buffer against negative spillover. However, rather than take an “oversimplified” approach in characterizing the work–family boundary as either integrated or segmented, research on boundary theory suggests that individuals can *both* integrate and segment their work and family (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012; Kreiner et al., 2009). That is, individuals may consciously choose which aspects of work and family to integrate and which to segment or may alternate between integration and segmentation. Thus, although home-based work has been portrayed as an extreme form of work–family integration (Ashforth et al., 2000; Clark, 2000), remote workers may still be able to segment their work and family roles in meaningful ways. In addition, just like work–family conflict is bidirectional, some remote workers might segment or integrate in one direction (e.g., work to family) but not the other (Hecht & Allen, 2009; Kossek et al., 2012). Indeed, boundary theory research has highlighted how individuals vary in the symmetry, or asymmetry, with which individuals allow one domain, work or family, to intrude on the other (Hecht & Allen, 2009; Kossek & Lautsch, 2012).

Furthermore, a person-centered view of boundary management emphasizes the importance for employees to have boundary control; that is, to enact a work–family boundary that is consistent with their preferences (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012; Wotschack, Glebbeek, & Wittek, 2014). For example, research suggests that the ability to control the work–family boundary in a way that reflects personal preferences has a greater effect on work–family outcomes than does the “mere act of integrating or separating” (Kossek et al., 2012, p. 124). Yet, despite a more personal view of boundary management, we

know little about how individuals' boundary management strategies interact with their work environment to influence work–family conflict and stress (Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015; Kossek et al., 2012). It is unclear if remote workers manipulate different aspects of their work environment to align with their desired boundary management strategy and to gain a sense of boundary control. Furthermore, given the inherent physical integration of work and home for remote workers, how they navigate work–family boundaries may be complex. As such, boundary theory may need to be adjusted to apply to remote workers.

In addition, it has been argued that research on the work–family interface is incomplete if it does not take into account gender because gender is deeply ingrained in work–family interactions (Powell & Greenhaus, 2010). The experience of working at home, its meaning, and the capacity to manage work within the family domain are fundamentally determined by the gender of the worker (Haddon & Silverstone, 1993). Although studies have shown that WFC and FWC are equally found among men and women (e.g., Frone, Russell, & Cooper, 1992; Powell & Greenhaus, 2010), men and women respond differently to competing demands between work and family and also interpret the meaning of competing demands differently (Greenhaus & Powell, 2006; Keene & Quadagno, 2004). Gender role theory proposes that there are differences in what are considered acceptable behaviors for men and women (Eagly, Wood, & Diekmann, 2000; Wood & Eagly, 2010). Although women's participation in the workforce and nontraditional occupations have increased in the United States and other societies, traditional gender role norms tend to persist, particularly those associated with the family role (Wood & Eagly, 2002, 2010).

When the workplace is located in one's home, it is not clear how men and women will manage the work–family interface. Some maintain that women highly benefit from the ability to work from home because it allows them to fit work around family responsibilities (e.g., Gajendran & Harrison, 2007). However, others have found no gender differences in the WFC and FWC of people who work from home part-time (Golden et al., 2006). Furthermore, boundary theory suggests that too much integration can increase the WFC of both men and women (Powell & Greenhaus, 2010). Yet, whether integration is more harmful to male or female remote workers is not known. Thus, in seeking to understand how male and female remote workers respond to work and family demands, it is necessary to consider their preferences for boundary management strategies and how they manage boundaries between their work and family domains. Our desire to investigate the work–family boundaries of remote workers and the consequences of their boundary management strategies led us to the following research questions:

Research Question 1: How does the physical integration of work and family create benefits and challenges for remote workers?

Research Question 2: How does the location of work in the home affect remote workers' ability to transition between work and family roles?

Research Question 3: How do male and female remote workers manage boundaries between their work and family domains?

Study I: Qualitative Study

For this research, we decided to employ a multi-method approach. Research studies using qualitative and quantitative methods are attracting greater attention because of the realization that qualitative research helps to better understand a phenomenon and produces insight, whereas quantitative research tests quantifiable relationships and helps to determine prevalence and generalizability (Jick, 1979; Lee, 1999). Qualitative research generally uses purposeful sampling to gain an understanding of what individuals experience and how they interpret those experiences, whereas quantitative methods require probability sampling to make statistical inferences (Bluhm, Harman, Lee, & Mitchell, 2011; Sandelowski, 2000). As such, although

qualitative research uncovers experience, processes and causal mechanisms, . . . quantitative research is appropriately poised to follow the qualitative beginnings by refining or calibrating the understanding of a phenomenon, uncovering the prevalence of an individual's experiences and generalizing those experiences to a larger population. (Bluhm et al., 2011, p. 1870)

Accordingly, the first stage involved an exploratory qualitative study whereby interviews were conducted with remote workers to gain insight into how they manage boundaries between work and family.

A total of 52 semi-structured interviews were conducted during a 6-month period with sales and service employees who worked remotely from home. We started with 34 employees of a large global firm that has a substantial portion of its employees working from home on a full-time basis. These informants were recruited with the help from a sales manager of the firm. After the first few interviews, informants were asked whether they knew other potential candidates for our research, which resulted in the referral of eight coworkers. Another 10 were recruited based on industry contacts. Care was taken to ensure that both genders as well as diverse functional areas were represented in the study. The informants were from the United States but dispersed all over the country. Informants worked in the fields of communications, sales, and marketing, public relations (PR), information technology

(IT), and finance. Only employees who worked from home on a full-time basis at least 35 hr per week were included in our study. Respondents' age ranged from 28 to 58 years and with work experience from 2.5 to 33 years. All the respondents had college degrees and 15 had master's degrees. Forty of the informants indicated that they had others living in their home (i.e., spouse, partner, children). Thirty-two of the respondents were female.

We constructed the research questions to identify the areas of interest, experiences, and challenges of remote workers. The interview questions were based on existing research rooted in boundary theory and extant research on telecommuting. Almost all the interviews were conducted via telephone except for two interviews that were done in person. Each interview lasted between 1 hr and 1 hr 40 min and followed the interview protocol in Appendix A.

During the telephone interview, informants were allowed to talk uninterrupted except for some clarifying questions. We were aware that telephone interviews lack the richness and social presence associated with face-to-face communication and lack the ability to monitor nonverbal cues (Andres, 2002). On the positive side, an informant can be more relaxed because she or he has more personal space and anonymity compared with face-to-face interviews (Sturges & Hanrahan, 2004). A meta-analysis by Leeuw (1992) showed that the differences in data quality between face-to-face and telephone surveys are quite small whereas Sturges and Hanrahan's (2004) study showed no difference between the two methods.

The interviews were recorded after seeking approval from each informant and then transcribed verbatim by a professional transcriber. The two researchers read the transcribed notes independently and manually performed the descriptive first-level coding. For analyzing the data, we followed the iterative process advocated by Sarah Tracy (2013), which alternates between emerging themes and the use of existing knowledge and theories. This involved a continual process of comparison between data, field notes, interpretations of informant statements, and existing theory to identify patterns and themes. During this process, the researchers often met to discuss the findings that were becoming apparent. We compared data in different categories with other instances of data, compared the applicable data with each code and refined the definitions to fit the new data (Urquhart, Lehmann, & Myers, 2010). We continued this process of discussions and searching for clues in the existing literature with several iterations and went back and forth until we both reached a consensus on themes. These themes included "need for a separate workplace," "flexibility and synergy," "cannot get away from work," and "work-family conflict or balance." We used *a priori* categories based on our literature review, which is an accepted method of coding in qualitative research (Hutchins, Burke, & Berthelson, 2010). When there were differences between

the researchers, specific informant statements were examined and statements prior and afterwards were reviewed to reach consensus.

The themes identified were used to revise and refine the format for the next interview, by adding additional sub-questions or prompts as necessary. Findings indicated that respondents' perceptions of the benefits and challenges associated with remote work varied as well as the mode of managing work and family demands. After coding 40 interviews, few new patterns or themes were repeating that caused us to feel that we were approaching the point of theoretical saturation (Locke, 2001). We therefore collected 12 additional interviews to ensure that we had reached theoretical saturation and to gather additional support for our preliminary framework.

Consequences of Having One's Workplace in the Home

We began the interviews by asking remote workers to describe their job and explain the benefits of working from home. Flexibility was the most common benefit mentioned. By working from home, the remote workers were able to alter their work patterns to manage work and family demands. Another benefit mentioned was the time saved preparing for work.

I can flex my schedule to be able to balance work and life so I can, you know, do everything successfully. (Female remote worker)

I can come and go as I need to. It's not like I have to get in my car and drive to the office. It's the convenience of having your computer at home. So, you integrate. Your work/life balance is much easier. I can go do my family things when I need to, but when I have a hot project that's going on, I can step away from my family for half an hour and do what I need to do. (Female remote worker)

The other personal benefit really is the time saving associated with not having to drive in to the office. I think there's also sort of a green impact as well. You know, using less gasoline to drive to the office by working out of my home. I can wake up in the morning and be at work in moments. (Male remote worker)

It could be 4:00 in the afternoon and you're still in your pajamas. I don't even shave sometimes. I could go two days without shaving. (Male remote worker)

When we further questioned interviewees about how working from home alleviates work–family conflict, they discussed how they are able to borrow time from one domain, work or family, to accommodate the other. Kreiner et al. (2009) described the borrowing and lending of time between domains

as the creation of temporal equilibrium. Whereas respondents in Kreiner et al.'s (2009) study discussed how time could be banked or borrowed over the long term, in our study, we found that remote workers tended to bank and borrow time on a *daily* basis. That is, during a 24-hr period, remote workers often flowed back and forth between work and family, taking "mini-loans" from one domain that they then repaid during the same day. This appeared to help the remote workers manage work and family demands so that priorities in one domain did not come at the expense of the other.

Working at home lets me be more flexible with my schedule. I could do that to some extent if I were going to the office, but its less well. What I end up doing is working at night to make up time. So I can pick (my child) up from school and spend time with her while she's awake. And then, I can work at night when she's asleep. So it makes my whole schedule more flexible. (Female remote worker)

So if I do step away for an hour because I need to feed my family, but somebody at work just sent a message to me about a big meeting, after an hour of preparing dinner I can come back and check that message will be sitting right on my computer for me. I can respond back to them even though it has been an hour later. (Female remote worker)

If you feel like you want to take some time off in the middle of the day, that's OK . . . Later, I'll just have to turn my computer back on and I have to do more work and that's OK. (Male remote worker)

The boundary flexibility associated with working from home appears to allow remote workers to synchronize the timing of work and family roles. However, as the examples above indicate, family demands often instigated the need for remote workers to seek temporal equilibrium between work and family. Due to greater proximity and accessibility to family while working at home, employees' productivity appeared to be hampered and their FWC increased. Many of our respondents often juggled work and family demands throughout the day. In her development of work/family border theory, Clark (2000) discussed the importance of "border keepers" such as spouses and bosses to an individual's ability to manage the border between work and family. Similarly, Kreiner et al. (2009) discussed how border keepers helped their study participants *maintain* the border between work and family, by screening phone calls for example. In our interviews, we found a few examples of border keepers who aimed to keep other family members from interrupting the remote worker's work. For example,

I try to remember to tell my children to not interrupt Mommy when they come home from school . . . They then tell each other to not interrupt Mommy if she is on the phone. (Female remote worker)

However, in our study we more frequently heard stories of “border breakers” than border keepers. That is, because the respondent was performing work in the home, family members, particularly the spouse, would often disrupt the respondent with demands, forcing the remote worker to transition from their work to family role multiple times throughout the day.

The work at home doesn’t quite work well because . . . family doesn’t understand that albeit I’m physically in the house, I’m at work . . . So I think the family thing presents a challenge if your family doesn’t understand this work at home concept. You know, your wife can’t be, running the vacuum cleaner two feet from your office or you can’t talk on a conference call. (Male remote worker)

When your wife sees you, she expects help with the dishes and this other stuff . . . And so, the work at home doesn’t quite work very well. (Male remote worker)

I think what’s often problematic is that there’s a lot of distraction at home. You know, I get distracted by my private life. It kind of interferes with my professional life. (Female remote worker)

Some participants recognized the likelihood that family members would be tempted to encroach upon their work and discussed how they tried to thwart such border violations.

When I get up in the morning, I’m very disciplined. I dress up casually, not in pajamas. I actually do look decent because I feel this is my working hours. And, I want to make sure my wife understands. I told my wife, “My office is off limits unless it’s urgent or an emergency. Then tell me from the door and then you can come in.” But I don’t expect anyone to come into my office. This is a business office. (Male remote worker)

Because these findings reveal that remote workers must often contend with family members interrupting their work, we expected a greater tendency for our respondents to describe FWC. But, as we further questioned participants about work and family demands, we uncovered a particularly strong sense of WFC; that is, work encroaching on family life. This finding is in stark contrast to research that has found that telecommuting lowers WFC (e.g.,

Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Golden et al., 2006; Raghuram & Wiesenfeld, 2004). Remote workers in our study explained how their organization expects them to be constantly available. In other words, because the remote workers worked from home, they felt the organization expected them to be working whenever they were at home. Thus, the organization appeared to encourage remote workers to partake in work at the expense of family time.

The workload has been such that it's just constantly overlapping. At (name of company) there is the expectation that you will work at night. (Male remote worker)

We have a little green light that says I am on, I am working. So all my boss has to do is look at my system and see if my little green light is on and instant message me . . . throughout the day. And if I respond, he knows I'm working and if I don't he might wonder where I am. (Female remote worker)

I think I probably tend to work a fifty hour week plus. I feel like if (name of company) is making it possible for me to work at home, and I'm not working like straight through those eight hours, then I feel like I owe it to the company to make it up at least, and then some. (Female remote worker)

In comparing how the remote workers described the encroachment of family on work and vice versa, it became apparent that they were more likely to view family as an "interruption" even though many allowed work to spill over into their family time. We also found evidence of remote workers placing pressure on other remote workers to be persistently available to each other to accomplish work for the organization.

When I have a salesman who is also working at home and I send them a message on instant messaging I expect them to come back to me if they're showing "available" in a matter of minutes. (Male remote worker)

Taken together, our findings on the costs and benefits of remote work extend research on work–family boundary violations by suggesting that when remote workers believe their work–family boundary has been breached, WFC and FWC ensue. Remote work is denoted by flexible and permeable boundaries whereby work and family are not tied to different places or times and cross-role interruptions easily manifest. Although the permeable boundaries of remote work may allow a remote worker to bank and borrow time between work and family thus helping to alleviate work–family conflict, the location of the workplace in the home appeared to encourage boundary violations from family and coworkers that exacerbated work–family conflict.

Furthermore, how boundary violations manifested and were described varied. Boundary violations initiated by family members tended to be described as “interruptions” and seen as something avoidable if family members respected that work was being performed by the remote worker. Conversely, the remote workers were much less likely to describe their coworkers as an “interruption” even though they often recognized that their work infringed on their family time. These findings contribute to Kossek et al.’s (2012) work on boundary control because the remote workers appeared more in control of *when* they worked (even if it spilled over into family time) than the need to interrupt work to meet family demands. Thus, a paradox seems to exist for remote workers. Although having one’s workplace at home may promote flexibility and temporal equilibrium in managing work and family, it may come at the expense of creating arduous expectations from work and family. In addition, despite work being located in the family domain, remote workers appeared to demonstrate greater acceptance for when work infringed on family than vice versa. This led us to further question how remote workers manage the permeability between their work and family domains and how they achieve a sense of boundary control.

Managing Boundaries Between Work and Family

With our second research question, we sought to uncover how remote workers transition between work and family roles and create boundaries. Recent research reveals that individuals may be capable of both segmenting and integrating different aspects of work and family allowing for “differential permeability” (Kreiner et al., 2009, p. 719). This suggests that although the physical location of work and family may be integrated for remote workers, some may still manipulate the boundary between work and family. Those who seek greater segmentation deliberately suppress unwanted transference of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors from one domain to the other. Such remote workers may also seek to create a tangible boundary within the home to segment where work and family roles take place, for example, by establishing a home office. Indeed, as we asked respondents how they managed the boundary between work and family, some explained how they attempted to instill a traditional office environment in their home thereby generating a tangible boundary between work and family. Some respondents also discussed the importance of establishing temporal boundaries, that is, designating specific times for work and family.

Now that I’ve moved into my new office, you might say my other room, at 5:00, or you know—close to there, I’ll get up and disconnect. I turn off the

same time. Turn off the laptop and close the door to the room. And you know, basically as if I headed out of a traditional office. (Male remote worker)

I try really hard to establish a boundary; when they can and can't access me and how they can and can't access me. (Female remote worker)

Others mentioned how they use rituals or routines to transition between their work and family roles. These efforts suggest that remote workers may deliberately suppress one role so as to transition to the other role.

You know, my other half has to go to work in the morning so that's great because I just follow that routine and a routine is important for me. If I don't get up and get a shower and get shaved and all that kind of thing, it just feels very strange. (Male remote worker)

When I get up in the morning I am very disciplined. I dress up casually; not in pajamas. I actually do look decent because I feel this is my working hours. (Male remote worker)

However, it also became apparent that not all remote workers sought to segment work and family. It appears some use the physical integration of work and family to further embed the two roles. Integration of role boundaries allows individuals to accommodate multiple roles and to more easily transition between the roles (Ashforth et al., 2000). For example, the following quotes suggest how some remote workers relish the physical integration of their work and family domains and appear to use this integration to foster smooth transitions between the two domains.

I like the fact that I'm able to go throw a load of laundry in. I can take an hour lunch and I can vacuum the living room. (Female remote worker)

I've been known to work in all parts of the house and to sit out in the back yard and read email and what have you. So I mean I really enjoy that aspect of it. . . . I can work from bed. I call it my play pen. You kinda pull all this, your laptop, book, and whatever else you need. (Male remote worker)

Accordingly, our findings appear to reflect a person-centered view of boundary management that highlights the importance of boundaries to reflect personal preferences (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012; Wotschack et al., 2014). Neither integration nor segmentation appeared to be a superior strategy. Rather, how the remote workers perceived their ability to control the boundary between work and family mattered. Although some respondents who

integrated their work and family roles seemed to express minimal work–family conflict, our interviews also revealed remote workers who appeared to use segmentation to ameliorate work–family conflict.

That is absolutely a problem, its constantly overlapping. I have a colleague who used to have her computer in her bedroom. I don't know how she did that. You know, right at the foot of her bed. I think I would have just blown my brains out. My computer used to be in the basement. We moved it upstairs, and now I'm in the office, next to my bedroom. And I've had to learn to shut the door. You know. I really try to shut the door. (Female remote worker)

When you have an office at home that barrier becomes very grayed out. Your office and family is together. You don't have a physical separation. So sometimes, I just go out. That helps. (Male remote worker)

I have learned to turn it off. Okay—this is something you must learn no matter you work at home or you work from a traditional office. It's very hard to do, but I've tried to discipline myself that I turn myself off. I just have to. So I can refresh myself and be fresh the next day. (Male remote worker)

Transitioning Between Work and Family

Next, we were interested in discovering whether boundary management strategies fully capture the complexity with which remote workers manage work and family and whether psychological effects manifest as a result of the workplace being located in the home. Our data suggest that working remotely creates situations wherein the work and family roles become less distinguishable and remote workers have difficulties exiting the work role. Beyond the individual tendencies toward integration or segmentation, our interviews revealed intriguing findings in regard to the ability of remote workers to transition from work to family. Our interviews uncovered a strong tendency for remote workers to have difficulties fully exiting their work role. Even remote workers who segmented their work and family roles by having a home office, for example, reported problems disengaging from work. Because boundary theory tends to assume that segmentation is associated with psychological disengagement from a role (Ashforth et al., 2000; Kossek & Lautsch, 2012), this finding provides an interesting nuance regarding the work–family boundary experiences of remote workers. Because their workplace is ever present in the home, whether they work from a designated home office or family room, remote workers explained that they often feel their organization's presence; that is—they feel they are constantly being pulled to work.

But you feel obligated to spend as much time, like you're chained to your computer. And there are times when I'll be like—"Wait a minute! I need to take a break." And it feels odd. If you were in the office, you go to the bathroom, you can chat with a friend, go outside for a walk, you'd run an errand. But when you're working from home, you feel more tethered to your work. (Male remote worker)

If you're sick . . . and working in the office, you go home and you're not working. But in working remotely you feel like if you are well enough, then you do work. It's hard to be sick when you're working remotely. (Female remote worker)

I think I work more hours sometimes because I work from home . . . Your computer is always on. A lot of people that work from home say they really work more often. (Female remote worker)

Most common were responses that centered on how they felt persistently "on." Many remote workers discussed how they had difficulties shutting work "off" and how they felt a persistent need to return to their work role even though it was not being asked by their organizations.

I have a propensity that my machine's always on. So I'll go in and check email at 10:00 at night before I go to bed. I'll respond to someone if I got an email that I thought would help them to get started on the east coast in the morning and I'm on the west coast. (Male remote worker)

Well that's the hard part. When you are working in the office, once you leave the office you mentally detach everything from work. You're done! Now your time is with family. But I still have work to do. I know I've got to go back to finish because my office is just two steps away. Nothing is preventing me from going and finishing the work I was doing. So the draw to finish the work is there . . . that pressure is always in the back of your mind. You cannot put off work. (Male remote worker)

Another challenge of working remotely is the work-life thing. I mean, if I have something planned like I have to take my daughter to swim or pick her up from school, yeah. But I know what my schedule is and I know I have to be back for a meeting or I have to be on a call. But do I shut off? No. I'm always on. You know, if I have a free moment I'm always on, working on a presentation or emailing someone or doing some research. (Female remote worker)

In reference to boundary theory, this pressure to always be "on" goes beyond role intrusions instigated by family members or coworkers. Rather, the data uncovered a sense of being pulled to work that the remote workers

felt made their work role particularly salient and difficult to disengage from, thus keeping them from transitioning to the family role. As such, the remote workers seemed to struggle with which role should take precedence in the home—work or family—and suffered from an inability to exit the work role. Many remote workers felt that because their workplace was in the home that they should remain in the work role whenever they were at home; the work role was ever present. Because the ability to psychologically detach from work benefits overall well-being (Sonnentag, 2003), an *inability* to disengage from work may be a source of stress. For example, respite during evening hours and vacations from work can prevent burn-out and stress (Westman & Etzion, 2001). When individuals psychologically detach from work, they do not indulge in work activities and stop thinking about work, which allows for recovery processes that reduce the negative effects of stressful work situations (Hahn & Dormann, 2013). Many of the remote workers we interviewed lamented over their inability to distance themselves from work and to refrain from performing work. Almost all the remote workers concurred that they find it difficult to disengage from work when home and as a result, work long hours, work at odd times, and work when they are sick. Some even expressed a sense of guilt for having the opportunity to work from home, which led them to work more hours.

I think that it is probably rare that I would work a 40 hour week. I think I tend to work a 50 hour week plus. You kind of feel like you should. I feel like if (name of company) is making it possible for me to work at home, then I owe it to the company. (Female remote worker)

I do find I work more hours. But, you know, I like the fact that I'm able to work from home. (Male remote worker)

Furthermore, as we dissected the interviews, looking for patterns in regard to the inability to disengage from work, our data revealed that a lack of detachment from work may be especially harmful to female remote workers.

You know one thing I wish is that there was not the expectation that everybody was on . . . I think that I give this company 120% of myself when I'm working. But because they don't see me there giving it, there is the expectation that it's not there. (Female remote worker)

Even though I don't get paid and I'm not supposed to work on Fridays, I still usually check my work a couple of times on Friday. If I have an extra hour, I will even check it Sunday night. If I don't do some work on those days off I actually feel stressed. I'm not sure why. (Female remote worker)

Everybody has Blackberries, everybody has a Thinkpad, everybody is global. So you have to be available all the time to talk to people in other parts of the world. And is it a good or a bad thing? Part of it is good. If you feel like you want to take some time off in the middle of the day . . . that's not a problem. That's the good side. The bad side is . . . that when I get home I have to turn my computer back on and I have to do more work. But that's okay. (Male remote worker)

Therefore, although we found that both male and female remote workers have difficulties disengaging from work, females were more likely to mention how an inability to disengage from work created problems in managing work and family demands. Drawing from Edwards and Rothbard's (2000) theory of work–family depletion, which views resources to cope with work and family demands as finite, our findings suggest that an inability to disengage from work infringes on the family role. Furthermore, heavy involvement in work appears more likely to deplete family engagement for women than for men.

How Men and Women Manage Remote Work

Finally, our third research question sought to uncover gender differences in how remote workers manage boundaries between work and family. In analyzing respondents' ability to manage work and family demands, gender differences emerged. Although some research would suggest that females are “integrators” and males are “segmentors” (e.g., Rothbard, 2001), our interviews did not reveal a strong gender difference in boundary management styles. Instead, our data revealed that when women integrated their work and family they seemed to express less work–family conflict than when men integrated the two roles. Female interviewees tended to identify integration as a positive aspect associated with working from home. Several females mentioned the ease with which they performed household tasks like laundry, cleaning, and preparing dinner while working at home. Conversely, male interviewees were more likely to see the physical blurring of work and family as a problem and source of work–family conflict. Thus, our interviews revealed that there may be important distinctions between the ways that male and female remote workers experience integration versus segmentation.

It actually makes my life a lot easier because I'm able . . . If you're driving to the office every day, you know, you have to do your errands, your laundry, clean your house. All that stuff has to be done at specific times. It's just made my life easier. (Female remote worker)

Working at home is for me. That no stress, that no driving. Don't have to figure out what I'm going to wear the next day. Don't have to worry about what I'm going to have for lunch. Don't have to deal with traffic. I can do laundry in the middle of the day so I don't have to do it on the weekends. I can, at lunch, clean my bathroom. It's made my life easier. (Female remote worker)

My issues are managing the workload/life balance thing because when you work from home, it's very easy to roll out of bed and start working and then, come 8:00, 9:00 roll back into bed (laughs) and so your days and nights become one. It's really very, very difficult. I'm probably very bad at this. Talk to my family. (Male remote worker)

In conjunction with our findings regarding an inability to disengage from work, our study suggests that male and female remote workers experience working from home, and particularly the overlap of work and family roles associated with remote work, differently. Gender role theory maintains that an emphasis on work, and specifically time allocated to work, is incongruent with female gender role expectations (Wood & Eagly, 2010). Indeed, research suggests that women are more negatively affected by overtime work than men (Rau & Triemer, 2004) and that women report greater work–family balance when they give priority to their family role as opposed to their work role (Keene & Quadagno, 2004). As such, it appears that how male and female remote workers gain a sense of boundary control and minimize WFC and FWC may vary. The presence of significant gender effects were therefore explored in our survey-based study and are further reviewed in our discussion.

Summary of Qualitative Study Findings

Taken together, our qualitative study revealed that working solely from home may not be the panacea for work–family conflict that others had suggested and that remote workers' FWC and WFC may induce stress. Although there seemed to be some advantages associated with working from home, particularly the flexibility associated with managing work and family demands, there also seemed to be disadvantages that could exacerbate FWC and WFC. These findings contrast with research that has found that a higher degree of telecommuting lowers WFC and that FWC is a greater problem than WFC (Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Golden et al., 2006); instead the remote workers in our study tended to focus on how work encroached upon their family. These results may be attributed to the fact that telecommuting is at the lowest range of the flexible work continuum because it is intermittent (Mulki et al., 2009), whereas in contrast, remote workers work exclusively from home. Therefore, how remote workers manage work and family appears complex

because their home comes to be associated with both work and family roles. Table 1 presents key constructs identified from our study, definitions, and examples from the data.

Remote workers who appeared unable to segment work from family and lamented over their inability to disengage from work were most likely to discuss WFC and FWC. Specifically, our interviews revealed behaviors that encouraged work to encroach upon the family for remote workers. For example, working late at night, checking emails during dinner, and staying virtually connected to the office during weekends. Because their workplace is located in their home, the remote workers seemed to struggle with constant cues in their environment that pulled them to return to their work role. Although the pattern of our qualitative results suggested that WFC is particularly prominent for remote workers, we also found that many respondents struggled with FWC. Most common were conflicts related to spouses/partners who expected the remote worker to assist with household chores. Among the female remote workers, 56% (16 of 28) versus 10% male workers (2 of 24) lamented that their spouse/partner did not respect boundaries between work and family and that they needed to work while at home. In turn, remote workers reported significant job stress due to conflicting work and family demands. However, whether WFC or FWC was more detrimental to stress could not be discerned; both seemed to matter.

Analysis of the interviews also suggested that the establishment of borders between work and family differentially affected male and female remote workers' ability to manage work and family demands. Although gender did not appear to be associated with a certain boundary management strategy, how men and women used integration versus segmentation seemed to vary. For a majority of men (69%), segmentation appeared key to their minimizing work–family conflict. In contrast, we found some women who successfully used segmentation and some women who successfully used integration to minimize work–family conflict, thus women did not appear to have as strong of a benefit from a segmentation strategy as men. In addition, although men seemed somewhat accepting of work's persistent presence and being “on” 24/7, women's inability to disengage from work seemed to be a significant source of WFC. For example, 64% of the female respondents mentioned how the constant presence of work in their home infringed on their family role and ability to enjoy time with their children. These findings suggest a need to examine the degree to which integration/segmentation and inability to disengage from work affect the WFC and FWC of male and female remote workers.

The findings from our qualitative study provided useful insights on the work–family experiences of remote workers that allowed us to uncover patterns of behavior that appear to contrast with some boundary theory and

Table 1. Main Themes of Remote Work.

Integration	Individual's preference to blend the work and family domains and minimize the boundary between the two domains (Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2009). Examples of integration from remote workers include working in the bedroom, alternating from work to household chores, working in pajamas.	"Yes, I have an office area, but it's also in a room where I have my son set up with me. And because I have a laptop, I can bring my laptop if I need to, in his room when he plays in his room. I just bring my laptop and I'm there with him. I normally have our big bonus room area where his activity area is set up. He's in there and I'm on the couch with my laptop."
Segmentation	Individual's preference to keep work and family separate by the use of boundaries between the work and family domains (Powell & Greenhaus, 2010). Examples of segmentation from remote workers include separate office space, mimicking office routines for lunch, and coffee breaks.	"I work really hard to separate it. We've tried to establish some rules with the rest of my family that they need to knock on my door before just barging in. That way if I'm on a teleconference, the noises that they make are not interrupting the people that are on the call."
Inability to disengage from work	Unable to detach from work psychologically. A set of attitudes, behaviors, and emotions that reflect actively engaging in work without break (Sonnentag & Fritz, 2007).	"My work is as close to me as my Blackberry and my computer. Mostly those are always on. And so I find myself doing work early in the morning, all throughout the day, and sometimes late into the evening. Even before I go to bed, you know, I'm checking email, You're just always on."
WFC	Form of inter-role conflict in which demands and pressures of work interfere with undertaking family-related responsibilities (Netemeyer, Boles, & McMurrian, 1996).	"If I have a call, I'll just log in. And, if it gets to be too crazy, then I can't do those things . . . a load of laundry or take a lunch. I just see myself blurring out, working early morning to late evening with no breaks for me."

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

FWC	Form of inter-role conflict in which demands and pressures of family interfere with undertaking work-related responsibilities (Netemeyer et al., 1996).	"My kids are still fairly young, so it is sometimes a little bit difficult for them to understand that Mommy's working. So, they'll come home from school and they'll be like, 'We're home, so we can go see Mommy.' So it's a little bit difficult for them to understand. So I try to remember to tell them: 'When you get out of school at 3:00, Mommy will be on an important conference call, so, you know, don't interrupt Mommy.'"
Job stress	A psychological and physical response of the body that occurs whenever one must adapt to changing conditions, whether those conditions are real or perceived, positive or negative (Michel, Kotrba, Mitchelson, Clark, & Baltes, 2011).	"So you have to figure it out. You have to use your life, and you have to use instant messaging, Face Book and email. You have to use those tools to get out there. So, you know, a good chunk of the company is feeling stressed about being networked and being remote."

Note. WFC = work-to-family conflict; FWC = family-to-work conflict.

telecommuting research. Most notable were findings related to the relative stress associated with WFC and FWC, whether integration or segmentation is most conducive to minimizing WFC and FWC, the relevance and effects of an inability to disengage from work, and gender differences. However, generalization from our study may raise concerns because of the small sample size and qualitative method. For example, small samples weaken the ability to generalize findings and to make recommendations (Cooke & Xiao, 2014). Furthermore, purposeful sampling and interview techniques can create biases that color interpretations and findings (Denzin & Lincoln, 2000). Finally, gender differences identified by our qualitative study require us to validate these findings with a larger sample and quantitative analysis (Bluhm et al., 2011). This led us to propose the following model based on the key thematic issues we identified from our qualitative study (Figure 1) to be tested via a survey-based study.

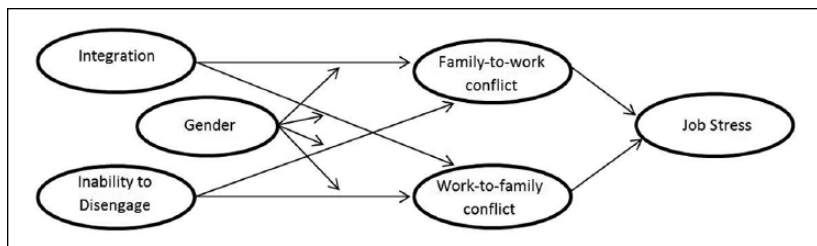


Figure 1. Proposed model.

Study 2: Quantitative Study With Survey Data

Method

Sample. A technology company with a large home-based sales force and an online firm with access to home-based sales and service employees throughout the United States provided the sample for Study 2. The respondents to our survey included sales, marketing employees, and customer service staff. This sample was collected in an effort to enhance the generalizability of our findings (Little, Smith Major, Hinojosa, & Nelson, 2015). To ensure that responses were only from remote workers, a screening questionnaire was used at the beginning of the survey. Respondents who worked from home less than 35 hr per week were exited from the survey.

A total of 315 responses were received in 2 weeks and 299 were coded for analysis after discarding incomplete responses. The age of respondents ranged from 20 to 60 plus years. Of the respondents, 132 (44.1%) were female and 161 (53.8%) male. Six respondents did not indicate a gender. More than half of the respondents (58.5%) were married or had a companion and 39.5% indicated that they were single. The number of people in the respondents' households ranged from one (single person) to eight (spouse, children, other) with 16.7% responding that they lived alone, 23.1% responding that a spouse or companion lived with them, and the remaining 60.2% responding that they had more than two family members living with them. In terms of education, 18.7% indicated that their highest education level was high school, 20.7% had associate degrees, 27.8% attended professional schools, 19.1% possessed an undergraduate degree, and 12.2% completed graduate school. Respondent's job experience ranged from more than 1 year to 40 years with a mean of 7.70 years ($SD = 8.19$ years).

Measures. Study measures and standardized loadings from the measurement model are shown in Appendix B. Cronbach's alphas for all scales were above

.70 indicating satisfactory internal reliability (Hair, Black, Babin, & Anderson, 2010; Pedhazur & Schmelkin, 1991). Unless otherwise noted, the constructs were measured with a 7-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*).

Inability to disengage from work was measured by adapting items from Sonnentag and Fritz's (2007) detachment scale. Whereas this scale assumes that employees can distance themselves from work by leaving the workplace and asks respondents to think about their "nonwork time over the past few weeks," our measure focuses on the degree to which respondents find it difficult to disengage from work on a regular basis. WFC and FWC were assessed with measures developed by Netemeyer, Boles, and McMurrian (1996). We chose these measures because they are based on the premise that WFC and FWC are distinct but related forms of inter-role conflict. Work-family integration was inspired by Kreiner's (2006) measure, which views work-family segmentation as the opposite of integration. However, because Kreiner's measure assumes that work takes place at an organization's location and not in one's home, we needed to modify the scale to accommodate remote workers. Higher values indicate greater integration. Job Stress was assessed with a measure created by House and Rizzo (1972) and adapted by Netemeyer, Maxham, and Pullig (2005) who added a fourth item to House and Rizzo's (1972) scale.

Control variables. Studies have indicated that demographic variables impact WFC and FWC (Michel, Kotrba, Mitchelson, Clark, & Baltes, 2011). To account for such variance, we controlled for marital status, job tenure, and number of family members in the household.

Results

Descriptive statistics and correlations are presented in Table 2. We also conducted a test to compare means for WFC versus FWC. Results indicated that respondents' WFC mean was significantly higher than FWC and the difference was statically significant ($t = 5.7$).

A measurement model was run using confirmatory factor analysis to assess the properties of the latent variables. The measurement model was acceptable with fit indices: $\chi^2 = 300.727$, $df = 125$, $p < .001$; comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.95; Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) = 0.923; root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) = 0.069, 90% CI = [0.059, 0.079] (Hair et al., 2010). Evidence of convergent validity was found as all the indicator loadings were significant at $\alpha = .01$. Discriminant validity was assessed by using the method prescribed by Fornell and Larcker (1981). Average variance

Table 2. Correlation Matrix and Descriptive Statistics.

Variable	Integration	Inability to disengage	FWC	WFC	Job stress	Tenure	Gender	Number of family members
Integration	.71							
Inability to disengage	.36	.74						
FWC	.58	.38	.94					
WFC	.48	.47	.62	.85				
Job stress	.25	.35	.43	.56	.89			
Job experience	-.02	.03	-.01	.02	.02	I		
Gender	-.01	.13*	.00	.08	.07	-.07	I	
Number of family members	.03	.05	.03	.07	.04	-.12*	.12*	I
Marital status	.04	.00	.07	-.05	-.05	-.32	.02	1.00
Mean	3.82	4.29	2.77	3.53	3.42	7.70		2.04
Standard deviation	1.25	1.50	1.68	1.57	1.58	8.19		1.51
Average variance extracted	.42	.52	.83	.70	.66			

Note. Bold correlations significant at .01 level (two tailed). Cronbach's alphas are on the diagonal; Gender: I = female; marital status: I = single.
FWC = family-to-work conflict; WFC = work-to-family conflict.

*Significant at .05 level (two tailed).

extracted for each of the factors was greater than the squared correlations for all pairs of factors thus providing support for discriminant validity.

Structural model. The model parameters of the structural model were estimated by AMOS 18 maximum likelihood method. For the hypothesized model, fit indices were within acceptable limits: $\chi^2 = 366.549$, $df = 167$, $p < .001$; CFI = 0.94; TLI = 0.92; RMSEA = 0.063, 90% CI = [0.054, 0.072] (Hair et al., 2010).

Taken together, results indicate that the model tested is acceptable. Furthermore, the high statistical power of the structural model ($\pi > .99$) indicates a low likelihood of not rejecting a *truly bad model* (McQuitty, 2004). The standardized path coefficients from the analysis show that work–family integration is positively related to FWC ($\beta = .81$, $t = 6.72$) and WFC ($\beta = .61$, $t = 5.63$). Inability to disengage from work is positively related to WFC ($\beta = .21$, $t = 3.06$) but not to FWC ($\beta = .05$, $t = 0.22$). WFC was shown to positively influence job stress ($\beta = .54$, $t = 6.84$), but the relationship between FWC and job stress was not significant ($\beta = .01$, $t = 0.15$).

The proposed model was based on findings from our qualitative study. An alternate model was tested by adding two additional paths (integration to stress, and inability to disengage from work to stress) to the current model. The difference in chi-square between the two models was significant ($\Delta\chi^2 = 11.037$, $df = 2$, critical $\chi^2 = 5.99$). Of the two additional paths, only the path from inability to disengage from work to job stress was significant ($\beta = .16$, $t = 2.41$). Other path coefficients did not show any significant differences. Table 3 provides details of hypotheses tested and standardized path coefficients and associated t values for the final model.

Common method bias (CMB) is a concern of survey-based studies. A latent methods factor (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003) has been used to account for CMB (Sonenshein & Dholakia, 2012). Accordingly, all measures in the structural model were loaded on a single latent factor in addition to their respective factors and a structural model was run with AMOS. Results showed that the pattern of results is replicated with similar path coefficients. This indicates that the pattern of relationships was not significantly affected by CMB.

Testing the moderating impact of gender. We conducted a multi-group analysis using AMOS 19 to test for the hypothesized moderation effects of gender in our model. Presence of moderation was determined based on significant chi-square differences between restricted and unrestricted path models. The sample was divided into two groups based on gender (male = 0, $n = 161$; female = 1, $n = 132$). Regarding moderation of the relationship between work–family

Table 3. Relationships Tested.

Hypotheses	Standardized paths	
1. Integration → FWC	0.81 (6.72)	Supported
2. Integration → WFC	0.61 (5.63)	Supported
3. Inability to disengage from work → FWC	0.05 (0.71)	Not supported
4. Inability to disengage from work → WFC	0.21 (3.06)	Supported
5. Gender moderates integration and FWC relationship	$\Delta\chi^2 = 1.36$ ($df = 1$)	Not supported
6. Gender moderates integration and WFC relationship	$\Delta\chi^2 = 3.21$ ($df = 1$)	Supported ($\alpha = .10$)
7. Gender moderates inability to disengage from work and FWC relationship	$\Delta\chi^2 = 1.86$ ($df = 1$)	Not supported
8. Gender moderates inability to disengage from work and WFC relationship	$\Delta\chi^2 = 4.09$ ($df = 1$)	Supported
9. FWC → Job stress	0.01 (0.15)	Not supported
10. WFC → Job stress	0.54 (6.09)	Supported
Control variable	Dependent variable	Standard β
Tenure with firm Tenure with firm Tenure with firm Marital status Marital status Marital status Number of people in household Number of people in household Number of people in household	Family—work conflict	.01
	Job stress	-.01
	Work—family conflict	-.09
	Family—work conflict	.07
	Job stress	-.02
	Work—family conflict	-.08
	Family—work conflict	-.01
	Job stress	-.03
	Work—family conflict	.03
		0.13
		−0.10
		−1.05
		1.39
		−0.41
		−1.41
		−0.12
		−0.54
		0.48

Note. Fit indices: $\chi^2 = 360.528$, $df = 166$, $p < .001$; CFI = .94; TLI = .92; RMSEA = .063, 90% CI = [0.054, 0.072]. CFI = comparative fit index; TLI = Tucker–Lewis index; RMSEA = root mean square error approximation; CI = confidence interval. FWC = family-to-work conflict; WFC = work-to-family conflict.

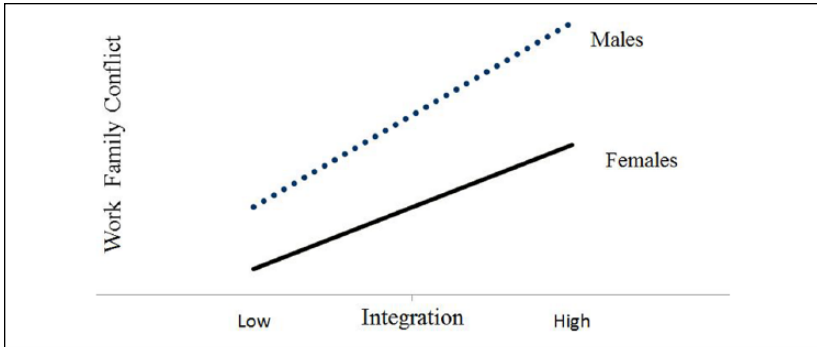


Figure 2. Integration and work-to-family conflict—Moderating impact of gender.

integration and WFC, because the chi-square difference ($\Delta\chi^2 = 4.09$, $\Delta df = 1$) was greater than critical $\chi^2 = 3.84$ ($p = .05$), gender was shown to significantly moderate the relationship. However, gender was not found to moderate the relationship between integration and FWC because the chi-square difference was not significant ($\Delta\chi^2 = 1.36$, $\Delta df = 1$). In addition, gender was shown to moderate the relationship between inability to disengage from work and WFC ($\Delta\chi^2 = 4.25$, $\Delta df = 1$) but not between inability to disengage from work and FWC ($\Delta\chi^2 = 1.87$, $\Delta df = 1$). To aid in the interpretation of the significant moderation effects, the interactions were plotted in Figures 2 and 3. Figure 2 demonstrates how high work–family integration has a more devastating effect on the WFC of men in comparison with women. Figure 3 plots the moderation effect of gender on the relationship between inability to disengage from work and WFC. This figure shows that whereas high inability to disengage from work has little effect on men’s WFC, it significantly increases the WFC of women.

Discussion

Using a multi-method approach our research sought to examine whether working solely from home minimizes the work–family conflict of remote workers, as the telecommuting literature suggests (Bailey & Kurland, 2002; Gajendran & Harrison, 2007), or whether its lack of boundary between work and family propagates work–family conflict as boundary theory proposes (Ashforth et al., 2000; Kreiner et al., 2009; Rothbard et al., 2005). Contrary to popular press that portrays working from home as a panacea to conflicting work and family demands (Chabrow, 2008; Meinert, 2011), we discovered a

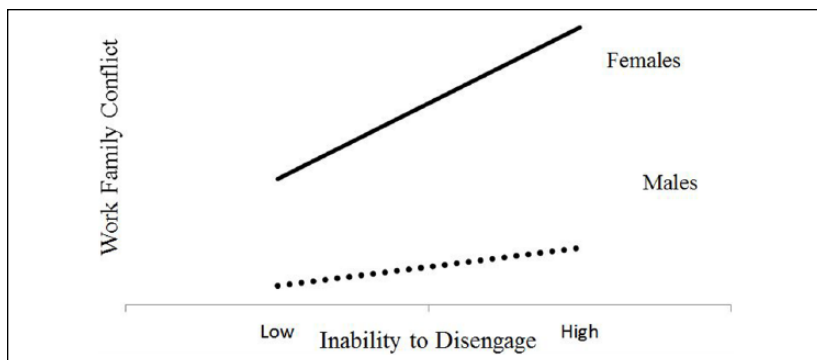


Figure 3. Inability to disengage from work and work-to-family conflict—Moderating impact of gender.

paradox whereby the presumed integration associated with working from home can come at the expense of increasing WFC and FWC. Although we initially expected remote workers who fully integrated work and family to experience the least work–family conflict based on the person–environment fit perspective of boundary theory (Kreiner, 2006), our qualitative study revealed that efforts to *minimize* integration seemed to alleviate work–family conflict. The results from the survey-based study supported these findings by demonstrating that high integration increases the WFC and FWC of remote workers. This is an important contribution to boundary theory and research on remote workers.

Working from home was also shown to be associated with an inability to disengage from work. Remote workers in our qualitative study often lamented how they felt a persistent pull to work, like they were “on 24/7” and “chained to the computer.” Although the telecommuting literature has consistently shown that working from home decreases WFC (e.g., Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Golden et al., 2006), both of our studies indicated that WFC is a significant problem for remote workers, particularly in comparison with FWC. Thus, although some tend to portray the family as a constraint reducing the ability of employees to accomplish work at home (Raghuram & Wiesenfeld, 2004), our multi-method study revealed that work was much more likely to encroach upon the family than vice versa. This has not been explicitly explored in previous research and contrasts with boundary theory research that tends to assume that employees transition from work to family when they physically leave their workplace to go home.

In addition, our results regarding gender suggest that various facets of the work–family boundary can differentially affect FWC and WFC. Although we

found that male remote workers need to highly segment their work and family roles if they are to minimize WFC, we also found that a persistent engagement in work did not harm men's WFC. Conversely, for female remote workers the integration of work and family roles was not as devastating to their WFC as it was to that of men. However, an inability to disengage from work significantly increased women's WFC. These results contrast with the view that home-based work may be a solution to women's problems with balancing work and family (Huws et al., 1996). They also suggest that the manner in which work breaches the family domain has a differential effect on men and women. Given that research tends to report equal levels of WFC among men and women (e.g., Powell & Greenhaus, 2010), these findings are important as they shed light on how the boundary between work and family is uniquely experienced by men and women. Thus, rather than focus on men's and women's inclination toward integration or segmentation, research should consider how boundary management strategies and an inability to disengage from work differentially influence the work–family conflict of each gender.

Our study contributes to research on the work–family interface and boundary theory by demonstrating the multiple layers of the work–family interface that exist for remote workers. Although each remote worker's workplace is physically situated in the family domain, we found varying degrees to which they further integrate, or segment, work and family. As such, even though work and family can be said to be physically integrated for remote workers, we found that many create temporal and tangible boundaries within the home to segment the two domains. Furthermore, in contrast to the person–environment fit perspective of boundary theory, we found that remote workers who are *unable* to create a boundary between work and family experience the greatest FWC and WFC. This finding extends boundary theory by suggesting that a boundary management style that *compensates* for a highly integrated work environment is most beneficial in managing competing work and family demands. Our qualitative study revealed a plethora of linkages between work and family that exist for remote workers—physical, psychological, and behavioral—that they use to erect or dismantle boundaries around to manage work and family. Due to the inherent physical integration of work and family for remote workers, those who were able to segment other aspects of work and family appeared to experience the least WFC and FWC. It appears that being able to segment some aspects of work and family offers remote workers a sense of boundary control that reduces their work–family conflict.

Furthermore, Study 2 showed that an inability to disengage from work increased WFC but was not significantly related to FWC which suggests that working solely from home leads remote workers to overwork and in turn, encourages their work to infringe on their family. Taken together with our

findings from Study 1, it appears that remote workers have difficulties transitioning from their work role to their family role. This contrasts with the view that the family is more salient for employees who work from home, and thus problems tend to arise in prioritizing work and completing work tasks (Raghuram & Wiesenfeld, 2004). Study 2 also showed that an inability to disengage from work is positively related to job stress. These results suggest that working solely from home not only creates an environment in which the workplace is physically integrated in the home but also often instills a persistent need to engage in work for remote workers. In addition, our results imply that integration should not be automatically inferred to be associated with less work–family conflict.

In studying remote workers it became clear the different ways in which the workplace can become embedded within the family domain. Although home-based work is inherently physically situated within the home, we also found perceptions that the organization infringes on family time, reports of work physically and psychologically encroaching upon the family domain, and habits and norms that form inducing remote workers to persistently remain engaged in work. We refer to this phenomenon whereby the distinction between work and home erodes as workplace embeddedness. More specifically, based on the findings from our two studies we propose three aspects that characterize workplace embeddedness: the extent to which (a) the home has come to be associated with the work role, (b) work physically and psychologically intrudes upon the family domain, and (c) habits and norms form that induce remote workers to be persistently preoccupied with work when home.

In our interviews, we repeatedly heard reports of remote workers feeling “pulled” to work and overworking to meet the perceived need to be available and respond to organizational requests “immediately.” They also described situations where their work materials spilled over into their dining-, family-, and bed rooms. Regarding habits and norms, respondents described routines involving the performance of simple work activities while cooking dinner or helping children with their homework, and dressing each morning in formal work clothes before entering a home office. Some would also habitually work on weekends and resume working late at night even though this additional work was not required by their organizations. As such, the workplace came to embed itself in the home for many remote workers so that when they were home, they felt they should be working. Their work seemed to bleed into their family lives and therefore, they seemed unable to discern when their work day should begin or when it should end.

Although many employees stay connected to their work while at home because of modern communication technology (Hahn & Dormann, 2013; Major & Germano, 2006), our research revealed a more complex phenomenon

whereby many of the remote workers discussed difficulties transitioning to the family role and remaining in the family role. Work appeared to spill over to the family domain so that many of the remote workers in our study seemed unable to fully transition from the work role to their family role. From our interviews, we also noticed that remote workers were more likely to describe a border breach by family members as an “interruption” in comparison with those made by coworkers. Although the demarcation between work and family time continues to erode due to advances in communication technology (Diaz, Chiaburu, Zimmerman, & Boswell, 2012), it may come at a price if individuals do not erect boundaries to protect their family life. The results from Study 2 showing that greater work–family integration increases FWC and WFC, and a greater inability to disengage from work increases WFC and job stress appear to further support the sense of workplace embeddedness that can come to plague remote workers. Certainly more research is needed to further investigate these aspects and to disentangle the complexity of the work–family interface for remote workers. Future research should explore the progression with which workplace embeddedness unfolds for remote workers and examine whether this phenomenon can also be found among those who work from home part-time. Because our study was performed in the United States, which tends to view the “ideal worker” as prioritizing work over family (Dumas & Sanchez-Burks, 2015), it would also be interesting to investigate whether and how workplace embeddedness manifests in diverse cultures. Finally, the effect of workplace embeddedness on family relationships should be considered.

Limitations and Practical Implications

Although there are strengths associated with a multi-method study, our research is not without limitations. Because the results of the quantitative study are based on cross-sectional data, causality should not be assumed. Furthermore, data for the qualitative study were collected using a targeted sampling approach, a type of snowball sampling technique that relies on the informal network of an initial sample to generate respondents. As such, the sample was not randomly selected introducing possible selection biases. In addition, our results may not apply to remote workers from all organizations and job functions. Another limitation refers to our use of Structural Equation Modeling (SEM). Researchers state that an SEM model has an infinite number of statistically equivalent models with equal fit (MacCallum, Wegener, Uchino, & Fabrigar, 1993). However, because our hypothesized model was guided by the findings from our qualitative study, this concern should be minimized. Future research should test our model using longitudinal data.

Turning to practical implications, whereas the popular press has tended to portray working from home as a solution to conflicting work and family demands (e.g., Meinert, 2011), our study suggests that the integration of work and family associated with remote work can spur FWC and WFC. Remote workers must be cognizant of the potential for work–family conflicts that can result from the blending of work and family domains. Organizations should educate remote workers on the need to establish boundaries between work and family, and train these workers to resist temptations to perform work activities during family time. In turn, managers and fellow employees must be trained to respect the work–family boundaries of remote workers and to not expect them to be “on call 24/7.” Although our findings on the inability to disengage from work were based on a sample of remote workers, we believe that this sense of being “chained to work” may also extend to other employees in this age of instant messaging and smart phones. Future research should compare the intensity and effects of an inability to disengage from work for traditional versus remote workers. In addition, it would be interesting to explore the cues associated with workplace embeddedness in the home that “call” remote workers to work and the boundary management strategies that could be used to minimize these cues.

In conclusion, our multi-method study identified unique challenges that remote workers face due to their work being embedded within their family domain. Unlike arguments in previous research (e.g., Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Golden et al., 2006; Raghuram & Wiesenfeld, 2004), our study suggests that too much work–family integration can be harmful to remote workers’ WFC and FWC. Furthermore, in contrast to the person–environment fit perspective of boundary theory, our study shows that remote workers who segment work and family, combining a physically integrated work–family environment with strategies to segment work and family, report the lowest WFC and FWC. Also, WFC appears to be especially problematic for remote workers due to an inability to disengage from work. Therefore, remote workers’ embeddedness of work in the family domain calls for a more nuanced approach to boundary theory and its implications for the work–family interface.

Appendix A

Interview Guide

This interview is part of a research project that aims to understand the personal and organizational challenges and coping strategies of workers in remote offices. We want to talk to you about your experience as a remote employee working away from a traditional office. Your participation is

voluntary—we would like to record this interview, but only so that we can use the information at the aggregate level to develop research patterns and findings. Your personal and organizational identity will be kept strictly confidential. You are free to stop the interview at any time or refuse to answer questions that you do not feel comfortable with. Are you willing to participate in this interview?

Before we start, we would like to record your age, educational level, and number of people in your household.

1. Briefly tell us about what you do in terms of your job, how long you have been with your company, how long you have been in a virtual work situation, etc. Please feel free to provide details.
2. How would you compare the experience of working in a traditional office with working in a remote office?
3. What do you think are some of the organizational benefits from having remote workers? Can you share with us an example of a “success story”?
4. What do you think are some of the family or nonwork benefits of working remotely? Can you share with us an example of a “success story”?
5. What are the key challenges and sources of stress in working remotely?

Can you provide us with descriptions of some of the challenges/problems you encounter as a remote employee? (*Note to interviewer—make sure the following issues are covered—ask for examples if not given*)

- a. Feelings of isolation
 - b. Reduced face time with supervisors
 - c. Loss of camaraderie
 - d. Reduced chances of career advancement
 - e. Loss of affiliation and social support
 - f. Work–family conflict/balance
 - g. Integration/overlap of work and family roles
6. If you were to rank order the top challenges encountered, how would you order the main issues we just talked about?
 7. Can you describe some of the coping strategies that you use in your role as a remote employee to lessen these challenges? Can you provide some examples?

8. Does your organization provide training before becoming a remote employee? Can you provide some details?
9. Can you please provide some details about how individual performance is evaluated?
10. Can you provide details about interpersonal communication between you and your manager? Among remote employees? (*Probe for mode, frequency, face-to-face meetings*)
11. What is the role of technology? How do you use it? How does it affect your work–family balance?
12. How does working from home affect your work and family roles? Can you provide some examples?
13. Please describe how working from home has affected your ability to balance work and family demands. Please provide some examples.

Finally, is there anything that you would like to add to help us better understand the benefits and challenges of working remotely?

Appendix B

Scale Items and Standardized Loadings.

	Standardized loadings
Work-to-family conflict	
Due to work-related duties, I make changes to my plans for family activities.	.574
The amount of time my job takes up makes it difficult to fulfill family responsibilities.	.910
The demands of my work interfere with my family.	.966
Family-to-work conflict	
The demands of my family/partner interfere with work-related activities.	.870
Things I want to do at work do not get done because of the demands of my family.	.968
My family interferes with my responsibilities at work, such as getting to work on time and working overtime.	.908
Job stress	
My job tends to directly affect my health.	.769
At the end of the day, my job leaves me “stressed-out.”	.864
Problems associated with work have kept me awake at night.	.791
I feel fidgety or nervous because of my job.	.839

(continued)

Appendix B (continued)

	Standardized loadings
Work-family integration	
I am often distracted when working at home.	.687
I expect nonwork distractions when working at home.	.446
I often carry out household chores during my work hours.	.708
I do not separate between work and family roles.	.723
Inability to disengage from work	
I work in the evenings.	.598
I think about work all the time.	.806
I make sure to check work-related emails or phone calls before going to bed.	.606
It's difficult for me to disengage from work.	.874

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